

S05-01 - Open Vale? Ritual Site

Player read-aloud

The trees stop all at once. Above you, the sky opens. Someone has installed a sign here, but the stones are much older than the words on it.

Scene summary

The party arrives at a perfect circular clearing older than its corporate name.

Visible choices

- Inspect stones
- Set perimeter
- Ask Custodian about past ritual

Player questions

- What detail in Open Vale? Ritual Site tells you the official story is incomplete?
- Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it?
- What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?

GM notes

- Emphasize that the place predates Goldspire. The brand is a sticker on a god's door.
- Keep player-facing information actionable. Reveal systemic truth through objects, reactions, and consequences before naming it.
- Manufactured-threat lens: seed the contradiction, do not explain it. The surface goal stays simple and heroic.

Checks and rolls

- Knowledge Read the ritual field and assign roles. Standard Better placement for countdown and defense. 15 Cleanly resolve: Read the ritual field and assign roles. Add a concrete boon, extra clue, or improved position. Success, plus the player names one helpful detail or asks one follow-up question. Success, but the GM exposes a cost, ticks a countdown, or reveals a new pressure tied to Open Vale? Ritual Site. The full goal slips, but the party still learns a useful truth or avoids the worst consequence. The GM makes a hard move that follows from the fiction and leaves the next choice visible. Spend Fear to tick the ritual countdown, expose the Custodian, activate ward backlash, or trigger Market Correction. On mixed or sliding results, reveal information in layers: visible fact, actionable clue, then systemic truth.

Clues

- Ward geometry Protect the center. Legacy failures arrive through old obligation paths. The site is a network node, not a battlefield by design.

Loot

- Open Vale residue after the ritual
- Keystone Asset?: Inside the sealed crate, packed in wax-paper and reassurance, sits a heavy grey stone the size of a loaf, warm to the touch, faintly humming, with a light deep inside it that is slowly going out.
- Whitefire Custodian's Ward-Charms: A small hand-carved wooden ratcoon mid-scamper has been thumb-worn smooth for luck. It is warm, and the forest feels a little kinder while you hold it.

Mechanics

- Plot So Far: The party is in Act Five pressure: The party arrives at a perfect circular clearing older than its corporate name.
- Mechanics In Play: Use Daggerheart Duality Dice as baseline. Use the listed Difficulty and outcome options when a roll matters. Keep trivial actions no-roll; roll only when uncertainty, cost, or danger is interesting.
- Roll Cards: s05-01-read-the-open-vale-pattern S05-01 Read the Open Vale pattern Read the Open Vale pattern Knowledge Instinct Knowledge Instinct 14 Knowledge reads the circle; Instinct feels what the clearing excludes. The ritual starts without a clear defensive map. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The ritual starts without a clear defensive map...
- Gm Fear Spends: Tick the Ritual Countdown the wrong direction or expose the Custodian. Trigger Market Correction, Pass-Through, Memory Delve, or Group Attack when fiction supports it.
- Conditions Hazards: No official condition unless a feature, hazard, or fictional position calls for Hidden, Restrained, or Vulnerable.
- Search Loot Clues: Open Vale residue: ward sand, regrowth signs, cold seal wax, humming chip.
- No Roll Guidance: Do not call for a roll when the players have time, a clear method, and no meaningful pressure.
- Escalation: Escalate by making cost visible: time, noise, trust, ward instability, or someone vulnerable in danger.
- Deescalation: De-escalate through respect, care, honest testimony, useful evidence, or a concrete concession.
- Tv Mechanics Caption: Public cue: Open Vale? Ritual Site asks what the party does, what it costs, and who is protected.
- Trait Variety Note: Primary traits in this scene: Instinct, Knowledge, Strength. If rolls drift toward Instinct/Presence, ask whether Agility, Strength, Finesse, or Knowledge better describes the action.
- Class Community Ancestry Reveals: Loreborne: spots older legal, heraldic, or ward-

craft language under the branding. Underborne: notices service doors, hidden routes, and who built the thing nobody credits. Highborne: reads etiquette, class panic, and reputational risk. Ridgeborne: notices stonework, weight, pressure, and structural weakness. Wildborne: reads the land, animals, and local ecological stress. Elf/Ribbet/Human/Giant/Katari: invite one sensory or social detail from the player's heritage. Sorcerer/Rogue/Warrior/Guardian/Ranger: give each class one table-facing way to shine without changing the plot.

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